

Cable

PREC: IMMEDIATE
CLASS: ~~CONFIDENTIAL~~
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LINE4: FM SECSTATE WASHDC
OSRI: RUEHC
DTG: 220127Z MAR 96
ORIG: SECSTATE WASHDC
TO: AMEMBASSY MOSCOW 4199-4201
INFO: ////
SUBJ: ~~(S)~~ CLINTON-YELTSIN MEMCON 3/13/96

DECLASSIFIED

PER E.O. 13526

2016-0118-M-5 (1.03)

6/1/2023 WJB

TEXT:

~~CONFIDENTIAL~~ STATE 058403

NODIS

EYES ONLY FOR AMBASSADORS PICKERING AND COLLING

CORRECTED COPY (NODIS)

E.O. 12958: DECL: 03/15/06

TAGS: PREL, RU

SUBJECT: (C) CLINTON-YELTSIN MEMCON 3/13/96

1. ~~CONFIDENTIAL~~ CLASSIFIED BY: JOHN HERBST ACTING,
S/NIS, DEPARTMENT OF STATE REASON: 1.5 (B) AND (D)

TEXT OF MEMCON FROM CLINTON-YELTSIN 3/13/96 MEETING
FOLLOWS FOR YOUR INFORMATION

BEGIN TEXT

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: MEETING WITH PRESIDENT BORIS YELTSIN OF
RUSSIA ~~(C)~~

PARTICIPANTS: UNITED STATES:

THE PRESIDENT

SECRETARY CHRISTOPHER, SECRETARY OF STATE

JOHN DEUTCH, DIRECTOR OF CENTRAL

INTELLIGENCE

ANTHONY LAKE, ASSISTANT TO THE PRESIDENT

FOR NATIONAL SECURITY AFFAIRS

RADM JOHN LEUCKE, DIRECTOR, STRATEGIC

PLANS AND POLICY, USCENTCOM

CLINTON LIBRARY PHOTOCOPY

H. ALLEN HOLMES, ASSISTANT SECRETARY FOR
SPECIAL OPERATIONS AND LOW INTENSITY
CONFLICT, DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE
ANDREW SENS, EXECUTIVE SECRETARY,
NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL
DIMITRI ZARECHNAK (INTERPRETER)

RUSSIA:
PRESIDENT YELTSIN
FOREIGN MINISTER PRIMAKOV
SECURITY ADVISOR RURIKOV
MICHAIL BARSUKOV, DIRECTOR, FEDERAL
SECURITY SERVICE
S. BEREZHKOV (INTERPRETER)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN WAS IN A GOOD MOOD AND LOOKED WELL (HE
SAID AT THE END THAT HE HAD LOST 12 KILOGRAMS). HE
CONGRATULATED THE PRESIDENT ABOUT HAVING RESOLVED
EVERYTHING OVERNIGHT AND HAVING ALREADY DRAFTED THE
CONFERENCE COMMUNIQUE. ~~(c)~~

THE PRESIDENT GAVE YELTSIN A COPY AND APOLOGIZED THAT IT
WAS ONLY IN ENGLISH. ~~(c)~~

FOREIGN MINISTER PRIMAKOV SAID THAT HE COULD READ IT,
AND YELTSIN JOKED THAT SINCE PRIMAKOV KNEW ENGLISH,
SECRETARY CHRISTOPHER SHOULD NOW LEARN RUSSIAN. THE
RUSSIANS WOULD BE GLAD TO PROVIDE THE SECRETARY WITH A
YOUNG ATTRACTIVE INSTRUCTRESS WHO WOULD WORK WITH THE
SECRETARY NIGHT AND DAY. ~~(c)~~

THE PRESIDENT JOKED THAT THIS WOULD CHANGE THE
SECRETARY'S IMAGE IN THE UNITED STATES. ~~(c)~~

THE PRESIDENT ASKED YELTSIN HOW HIS ELECTION CAMPAIGN
WAS GOING. ~~(c)~~

YELTSIN REPLIED THAT BILL CLINTON'S CAMPAIGN WAS GOING
WELL, AND HE WOULD BE ELECTED IF THE ELECTION TOOK PLACE
NOW ~~(c)~~

THE PRESIDENT AGREED, BUT NOTED THAT THERE WERE STILL
EIGHT MONTHS TO GO. ~~(c)~~
FOREIGN MINISTER PRIMAKOV, HAVING LOOKED AT THE
COMMUNIQUE, INDICATED THAT IT WAS A GOOD ONE. ~~(c)~~

THE PRESIDENT THANKED YELTSIN FOR COMING TO THE SUMMIT
THIS WOULD BOOST THE PEACE PROCESS AND HELP PERES AND
ARAFAT CONFIDENCE IN ISRAEL HAD PLUMMETED AFTER THE
BOMBINGS, AND THIS WOULD HELP TO IMPROVE THE SITUATION
~~(c)~~

YELTSIN AGREED HE SAID HE HAD NO RESERVATIONS ABOUT
COMING, ESPECIALLY SINCE RUSSIA WAS A COSPONSOR OF THE
PEACE PROCESS HE THEN SAID THAT HE WANTED TO REPLY TO
THE PRESIDENT'S QUESTION ABOUT THE ELECTION CAMPAIGN IN
RUSSIA. ~~(c)~~

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YELTSIN'S PEOPLE HAVE BEGUN TO GET GEAREDUP STAFF, COMMITTEES, PERSONNEL HAD BEEN PUT TOGETHER THROUGHOUT RUSSIA -- DOWN TO THE VILLAGES THE OFFICIAL REGISTRATION OF CANDIDATES WOULD TAKE PLACE APRIL 5. A CANDIDATE NEEDED ONE MILLION SIGNATURES TO BE ON THE BALLOT. HE, YELTSIN, HAD OVER 6 MILLION AND YELTSIN'S TAX DECLARATION, SUBMITTED TO THE CENTRAL ELECTION COMMITTEE, DID NOT CONTAIN ANYTHING TO RAISE QUESTIONS, JUST AS PRESIDENT CLINTON'S DID NOT. ~~(e)~~

THE PRESIDENT OBSERVED THAT WORKING FOR THE GOVERNMENT DOES NOT GIVE ONE A BIG SALARY ~~(e)~~

YELSTIN CONTINUED THAT HE WOULD GIVE A SPEECH OUTLINING HIS PLATFORM TO ABOUT 5,000 SUPPORTERS AND THEN GET DOWN TO THE NUTS AND BOLTS OF THE CAMPAIGN ON APRIL 6. PORTY-NINE CANDIDATES HAD DECLARED, BUT YELTSIN DID NOT THINK THAT MORE THAN 5 OR 6 OF THEM WOULD BE ABLE TO GET THE NECESSARY NUMBER OF SIGNATURES. THE AIM OF YELTSIN AND HIS SUPPORTERS WOULD BE TO CONVINCE THE CANDIDATES ONE-BY-ONE TO WITHDRAW FROM THE RACE AND TO THROW THEIR SUPPORT BEHIND YELTSIN. THE ONE CANDIDATE WHO WOULD NOT AGREE TO DO THIS WAS ZYUGANOV. HE IS A DIE-HARD COMMUNIST, AND YELTSIN WOULD NEED TO DO BATTLE WITH HIM. GORBACHEV WAS NOT A SERIOUS CANDIDATE -- HE HAD AWOKEN ONE MORNING AND DECIDED TO RUN AND WOULD WAKE UP ANOTHER MORNING AND DECIDE TO WITHDRAW HIS CANDIDACY. THIS WOULD BE BETTER FOR HIM BECAUSE HE NOW HAD SOME STANDING, AND IF HE PARTICIPATED IN THE ELECTIONS, HE WOULD LOSE ANY REPUTATION HE HAD LEFT. ~~(e)~~

YELTSIN CONTINUED THAT HE WOULD NEED TO TRAVEL INTENSELY THROUGHTHOUT RUSSIA FOR TWO MONTHS TO TALK TO THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE, TO GET HIS MESSAGE TO EVERY APARTMENT, HOUSE AND PERSON. ~~(e)~~

YELTSIN'S PROGRAM WOULD ONLY BE AIMED AT INCREASING DEMOCRACY AND DEEPENING REFORMS. HE WOULD NOT DEVIATE FROM THAT PATH. TO IMPROVE HIS RATINGS, HIS PEOPLE HAVE CREATED THEIR OWN POLLING ORGANIZATION, TO OFFSET THE COMMUNIST POLLING ORGANIZATIONS, WHICH FABRICATE THINGS THAT DON'T EXIST. ~~(e)~~

YELTSIN CONTINUED THAT AS RECENTLY AS A MONTH AGO, HE STILL HAD DOUBTS ABOUT RUNNING, BUT AFTER HE SAW THE COMMUNIST PLATFORM, HE DECIDED TO RUN. THE COMMUNISTS WOULD DESTROY REFORM, DO AWAY WITH PRIVATIZATION, NATIONALIZE PRODUCTION, CONFISCATE LAND AND HOMES. THEY WOULD EVEN EXECUTE PEOPLE. THIS WAS IN THEIR BLOOD. IT WOULD BE A DISASTER FOR RUSSIA AND MANY OTHER COUNTRIES. SO YELTSIN AGREED TO RUN AND NOW FELT BETTER AND MORE OPTIMISTIC ABOUT THE SITUATION HE HAD TRAVELED THROUGH RUSSIA AND HAL) FELT THE PUBLIC'S SUPPORT BUT HE ADMITTED THAT HE SHOULD NOT BE OVER CONFIDENT ~~(e)~~

THE PRESIDENT INDICATED THAT THERE WAS NOT MUCH TIME, PUT HE WANTED TO SAY A FEW THINGS ABOUT THE? ELECTIONS.

CLINTON LIBRARY PHOTOCOPY

FIRST OF ALL, HE WANTED TO MAKE SURE THAT EVERYTHING THE UNITED STATES DID WOULD HAVE A POSITIVE IMPACT, AND NOTHING SHOULD HAVE A NEGATIVE IMPACT. HE WAS ENCOURAGED THAT THE SECRETARY OF STATE WAS HEADING TO MOSCOW TO MEET WITH MINISTER PRIMAKOV, AND HE WANTED THE APRIL SUMMIT TO BE A POSITIVE EVENT. THE UNITED STATES WOULD WORK WITH RUSSIA TO ENSURE THIS, SO THAT IT WOULD REINFORCE EVERYTHING THAT YELTSIN HAD DONE IN THIS REGARD ~~(c)~~

YELTSIN NOTED THAT PREPARATIONS FOR THE MULTILATERAL SUMMIT IN MOSCOW ON APRIL 20 WOULD OCCUPY HIM FULLY ON APRIL 19, BUT AFTER THE SUMMIT ON APRIL 20, HE WOULD BE HAPPY TO MEET FOR THREE TO FOUR HOURS WITH PRESIDENT CLINTON TO DISCUSS BILATERAL ISSUES. HE ADDED THAT A LEADER OF INTERNATIONAL STATURE SUCH AS PRESIDENT CLINTON SHOULD SUPPORT RUSSIA AND THAT MEANT SUPPORTING YELTSIN. THOUGHT SHOULD BE GIVEN TO HOW TO DO THAT WISELY. ~~(c)~~

TUE PRESIDENT REPLIED THAT SECRETARY CHRISTOPHER AND MINISTER PRIMAKOV WOULD TALK ABOUT THAT. THE MAIN THING IS THAT THE TWO SIDES NOT DO ANYTHING THAT WOULD HARM THE OTHER. THINGS COULD COME UP BETWEEN NOW AND THE ELECTIONS IN RUSSIA OR THE UNITED STATES, WHICH COULD CAUSE CONFLICTS. PERHAPS THE GORE-CHERNOMYRDIN PROCESS COULD BE RELIED ON MORE TO RESOLVE THESE ISSUES, SUCH AS

THE POULTRY ISSUE WHICH RECENTLY AROSE. THIS IS A BIG ISSUE, ESPECIALLY SINCE ABOUT 40 PERCENT OF U.S POULTRY IS PRODUCED IN ARKANSAS. ON THE OTHER HANDR OF COURSE, RUSSIA HAD LEGITIMATE ISSUES ABOUT INSPECTIONS OF U.S. PRODUCE. BUT THIS QUESTION SHOULD BE ON ITS WAY TO RESOLUTION, AND AN EFFORT SHOULD BE MADE TO KEEP SUCH THINGS FROM GETTING OUT OF HAND. ~~(c)~~

YELTSIN INTERJECTED "USE DIRECT CHANNELSR " THEN WENT ON TO NOT3 THAT THE MAIN THING WAS THAT THE U.S. INSPECTORS CONFIRMED THAT THERE HAD BEEN VIOLATIONSR AND NOW WE WERE BACK IN BUSINESS. BUT LET THE GORE-CHERNOMYRDIN CONTACTS CONTINUE ON THIS. ~~(c)~~

THE PR3SIDENT CONCLUDED THAT HE WAS LOOKING FORWARD TO TODAY'S MEETINGS AND THE ONES IN APRIL. ~~(c)~~

END OF CONVERSATION
TALBOTT
BT
#8403

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SECT: SECTION: 01 OF 01

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Withdrawal/Redaction Sheet

Clinton Library

DOCUMENT NO. AND TYPE	SUBJECT/TITLE	DATE	RESTRICTION	
001, cable	Re: [Message from President Clinton to President Yeltsin] (2 pages)	03/09/1996	P1/b(1)	WJB
002, cable	Re: "Summit of the Peacemakers" Conference in Egypt (2 pages)	03/10/1996	P1/b(1)	WJB
003, cable	Re: Clinton Yeltsin Memcon 3/13/96 (5 pages)	03/22/1996	P1/b(1)	WJB
004, cable	Re: Russians Protest Leak of Sharm Memcon (2 pages)	03/29/1996	P1/b(1)	WJB

COLLECTION:

Clinton Presidential Records
NSC Cables
Jan 1995 - Dec 1996 ([Sharm el Sheikh...])
OA/Box Number: 510000

FOLDER TITLE:

[03/09/1996 - 03/29/1996]

Kara Ellis
2016-0118-M
ke4034

RESTRICTION CODES

Presidential Records Act - [44 U.S.C. 2204(a)]

- P1 National Security Classified Information [(a)(1) of the PRA]
- P2 Relating to the appointment to Federal office [(a)(2) of the PRA]
- P3 Release would violate a Federal statute [(a)(3) of the PRA]
- P4 Release would disclose trade secrets or confidential commercial or financial information [(a)(4) of the PRA]
- P5 Release would disclose confidential advice between the President and his advisors, or between such advisors [(a)(5) of the PRA]
- P6 Release would constitute a clearly unwarranted invasion of personal privacy [(a)(6) of the PRA]

C. Closed in accordance with restrictions contained in donor's deed of gift.

PRM, Personal record misfile defined in accordance with 44 U.S.C. 2201(3).

RR, Document will be reviewed upon request.

Freedom of Information Act - [5 U.S.C. 552(b)]

- b(1) National security classified information [(b)(1) of the FOIA]
- b(2) Release would disclose internal personnel rules and practices of an agency [(b)(2) of the FOIA]
- b(3) Release would violate a Federal statute [(b)(3) of the FOIA]
- b(4) Release would disclose trade secrets or confidential or financial information [(b)(4) of the FOIA]
- b(6) Release would constitute a clearly unwarranted invasion of personal privacy [(b)(6) of the FOIA]
- b(7) Release would disclose information compiled for law enforcement purposes [(b)(7) of the FOIA]
- b(8) Release would disclose information concerning the regulation of financial institutions [(b)(8) of the FOIA]
- b(9) Release would disclose geological or geophysical information concerning wells [(b)(9) of the FOIA]

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